

BLACK HERITAGE RECLAIMED

Voice Script - Auntie Liza

Line code format: AL-[scene]-[line] e.g. AL-01-003

Messam Multimedia - Guelph Black Heritage Society

HOW TO READ THIS SCRIPT

Setting: *Italic text at the top of each scene. Describes where we are and what is happening in the world.*

[ENV]: *Environmental cues - what the world does, how the scene responds. Not spoken.*

AL-##-###: Line code followed by the spoken dialogue. Each code matches the audio file name.

Note on performance: Auntie Liza is warm, direct and grounded. She has been on this road before and she is walking it again. She speaks from experience. Let the pauses be real. She does not rush anything except when the story requires it.

PROLOGUE

AL-00-001 "What you are about to experience is a dramatization. It is drawn from the real history of the Underground Railroad."

AL-00-002 "Between 1820 and 1865, when slavery was finally abolished, hundreds of thousands of Black people were held in bondage across the American South."

AL-00-003 "They were bought and sold. They were separated from their families. Their names, their labor, their children; none of it was considered theirs by the law of the land."

AL-00-004 "Some chose to run."

AL-00-005 "Under the Fugitive Slave Act of 1850, even those who reached free states in the North could be legally seized and returned. Nowhere in the United States was safe."

AL-00-006 "The only true sanctuary was Canada and Canada was hundreds of miles away, through wilderness, across rivers, past checkpoints and patrols, on roads where the wrong face at the wrong hour could cost you everything."

AL-00-007 "The people who helped freedom seekers escape were called conductors. They operated in secret, at great personal risk. They needed a way to communicate that couldn't be read by anyone who wasn't meant to read it."

AL-00-009 "The answer was sewn in cloth."

AL-00-010 "Quilts were hung in windows, draped over fences, left on lines and to the eye of anyone who knew the code, they were a map. Each pattern carried a message."

AL-00-011 "You are about to walk one version of that road."

AL-00-012 "You will be guided by a conductor. You will learn the patterns. You will make the crossing."

AL-00-013 "Everything in this experience is grounded in documented history."

AL-00-014 "Their story does not belong to the past. It begins now."

SCENE 01 / THE QUILT AWAKENS

A cramped hiding space. Almost no light - Auntie Liza's lantern is shuttered down to a thin line of amber. Through a crack in the wall, a quilt hangs in a window across the way. Three days of silence are ending. She slips in and crouches low.

[Auntie Liza enters, lantern nearly closed. She sets a small flask of water on the ground between them.]

AL-01-001 "My name is Liza. People on this road call me Auntie Liza."

AL-01-002 "Drink before we go anywhere."

[She waits.]

AL-01-003 "We have a long road ahead."

[She nods toward the crack in the wall. The quilt visible outside.]

AL-01-004 "Do you see that quilt out there? In that window."

AL-01-005 "That is a message. Someone hung it there for someone exactly like you, tonight."

AL-01-006 "Every pattern on that cloth means something. I am going to teach you how to read them."

AL-01-007 "But first, if you seek freedom, let it know you are ready. Raise your hands or say freedom"

[The quilt illuminates. Patterns glow outward from the center. The room fills with reflected warm light]

AL-01-008 "There it is."

[She points to one specific block on the quilt. The Crossroads pattern.]

AL-01-009 "That one - the Crossroads. That is where we are headed. Point to it with me."

[The block pulses as it is indicated.]

AL-01-010 "Good. Remember that shape."

[The quilt's patterns settle into a soft glow.]

AL-01-011 "We are not going back to this place. Not tonight. Not ever."

SCENE 02 / CROSSROADS

Open road, dark. The road forks ahead. The sound of a creek is audible somewhere nearby - water crossing under this junction. Auntie Liza walks beside the player, lantern shuttered. She stops at the fork.

AL-02-001 "The first time I walked this road, I stood at a crossroads just like this one and I could not move."

AL-02-002 "Not from fear. Because I had never in my life made a choice that was only mine to make."

AL-02-003 "That is what the Crossroads pattern means. Not a junction in the road but the moment you stop waiting for someone else to decide."

AL-02-003b "The Crossroads pattern was first named for Cleveland. A real city, a crossroads where many different routes to Canada come together."

AL-02-004 "Two paths. I know what is on both of them. Neither is easy and both go north."

AL-02-005 "Listen first."

[She tilts her head. Beneath the creek sound, a low coded signal somewhere ahead.]

AL-02-006 "You hear that? Someone went this way not long before us. This road has been walked."

[Both paths visible ahead. The world waits.]

AL-02-007 "Choose where you are going. Point to it."

[The chosen path lightens slightly - the darkness stepping back.]

AL-02-008 "When you're sure of your path, say go."

[Voice cue: player says 'Go'. The path confirms.]

AL-02-009 "No going back. Don't be nervous, that is not a bad thing."

[They begin to move. The creek fades behind them.]

SCENE 03 / FLYING GEESE

Dawn breaking. They have walked through the night. Open country, pale sky, long grass. The sound of wingbeats overhead - a flock of geese crossing north. Auntie Liza extinguishes the lantern as the light arrives. She looks up.

[Dawn. The geese cross the brightening sky. Auntie Liza's face opens - the first ease in the whole journey.]

AL-03-001 "Look up."

AL-03-002 "Those birds have been flying north every spring since before any of our families were brought to this land. They don't need a map. They just go."

AL-03-003 "The Flying Geese pattern was hung to say: follow what nature is showing you. The birds know where water is. When you are lost and the road is gone - look up. They will be there."

AL-03-004 "Shade your eyes. Track where they are going."

[The geese cross the sky left to right. The environment brightens in their wake.]

AL-03-005 "North. That direction, right there."

AL-03-006 "Do you see the path they travel? There is water below that flight line. Always is. Point it out - we will need it."

[A river glints in the landscape below the geese line.]

AL-03-007 "Good."

[Voice cue window - if player says 'North' the geese ripple in response.]

AL-03-008 "North. Say it again when you are tired. It helps." *[reaction to voice cue]*

[The lantern sits cold, unlit. They do not need it in this light.]

AL-03-009 "Tonight I am going to show you something nobody can take away."

AL-03-010 "We are moving through Ohio now. The border is not far, let's keep moving."

SCENE 04 / NORTH STAR

Night again. They have sheltered beside a slow stream - water audible and close throughout this scene. Sky is open and clear. Auntie Liza relights the lantern, keeps it dim and close to the ground. She sits beside them.

[The lantern relit - small, low. Stars overhead. Stream sound constant beneath.]

AL-04-001 "I need to tell you something."

AL-04-002 "If we get separated - and I pray we do not - this is how you find north without me."

AL-04-003 "That star at the top of the sky. The one that is not moving while everything else turns. That is Polaris. The North Star."

AL-04-004 "Every other star rises and sets. That one never moves. It has been there for everyone who ever needed it."

AL-04-005 "There was a song - Follow the Drinking Gourd - passed around in work songs, in whispers. Hidden in the words was a map of the sky. The Big Dipper points straight to Polaris, every time. Without fail."

AL-04-006 "I will show you and then you will find it yourself."

[The Big Dipper becomes visible in the star field. The stream reflects the stars below it.]

AL-04-007 "Show me the gourd first. Four stars for the bowl, three for the handle."

[The constellation responds - tracing complete.]

AL-04-008 "Follow where the water would pour out. Where does it point?"

[The North Star ignites.]

AL-04-009 "Draw the star yourself. One finger."

[Polaris blazes to life.]

AL-04-010 "That is yours. Say "follow the gourd""

[Voice cue - 'Follow the gourd'. The star pulses brighter.]

AL-04-011 "Yes. The people who sang that song were singing a map. You just sang it." *[reaction to voice cue]*

[The held-arm gesture. The star holds.]

AL-04-012 "Point your arm toward it and hold."

AL-04-013 "That star will never move. And now you know how to find it."

AL-04-014 "Wherever you end up - you know which way is north."

[The stream runs. She settles. The lantern glows small beside them.]

AL-04-015 "Rest if you can. Tomorrow will ask everything of us."

SCENE 05 / MONKEY WRENCH

Pre-dawn, beside the stream. Last quiet moment before they move into danger. Auntie Liza has laid out what they are carrying on a flat rock. The flask from Scene 1 is filled from the stream first - water is the first thing packed.

[Lantern still lit, low. Items on the rock. She fills the flask from the stream and sets it aside first.]

AL-05-001 "The Monkey Wrench pattern said: gather your tools. Greater than what your hands can carry. It's what your mind knows and what you can hold onto when everything else is stripped away."

AL-05-002 "I have seen people leave with so much they could not move fast enough. And I have seen people leave with nothing but their own name and make it through."

AL-05-003 "We are going to be deliberate about this. Look at what we have."

[Tool 1 - water flask, already filled.]

AL-05-004 "Water first. Already done."

[Tool 2 - food bundle.]

AL-05-005 "Three days of food, pressed flat so it does not show. Hover over it - take it when you are ready."

[Tool 3 - rope.]

AL-05-006 "Rope. Thin - for water crossings. You do not know yet when you will need it. That is exactly why we take it."

[Tool 4 - dark cloth.]

AL-05-007 "Dark cloth. For your face and hands at night. You become part of the dark. Shadow does not get caught."

[Tool 5 - the lantern. She looks at it before setting it out.]

AL-05-008 "The lantern."

AL-05-009 "Use it only when you must. The dark is your protection on this road. But when you need to see - this."

[Final - the code. Not a physical object. A glowing symbol.]

[She asks for the temple gesture before taking this one.]

AL-05-010 "And this last gift you cannot hold in your hand."

AL-05-011 "Everything you have learned about the quilt codes. Every pattern. It lives in you now. Touch your own head."

AL-05-012 "No one can search you for that. No one can take it off you."

AL-05-013 "That is the most important thing you are carrying."

[She presses her hands together. Done.]

AL-05-014 "There is a house about a mile ahead. I know the person inside. They are expecting us."

SCENE 06 / SHOOFLY

Night. A quiet road. A house with one warm window. A Shoofly quilt pattern near the door. Auntie Liza dims the lantern completely before they approach - it disappears into the pack.

[Lantern closed - gone from sight. Darkness except for the house window. The Shoofly pattern just visible near the door.]

AL-06-001 "That pattern - the Shoofly. That means this is a safe house."

AL-06-002 "Someone inside decided the risk was worth it. Decided that strangers on the road were worth their life to help."

AL-06-003 "The Underground Railroad is not a thing. It is people. Hundreds of them, in houses like this one, on roads like this one, who said: come in. I have you."

AL-06-004 "But the knock has to be right. Three beats - short, short, long. Watch."

[She demonstrates. Tap. Tap. Hold.]

AL-06-005 "Check the road. Left."

[Clear.]

AL-06-006 "Right."

[Clear.]

AL-06-007 "Now knock."

[The three-knock rhythm sounds. A pause. Then the door opens - slow, amber light from the crack.]

AL-06-008 "Hold still. Hands open. Let them see you."

[A hand extends from the doorway.]

AL-06-009 "Take it."

[The hand is clasped.]

AL-06-010 "You may never know that person's name. But they opened that door."

[Inside, briefly - the sound of water. A cup set down.]

AL-06-011 "The conductor says we are two days from the Niagara River."

AL-06-012 "There are people working out of St. Catharines, on the other side of that river. They have brought many people across."

AL-06-013 "The next stretch is through the wilderness. It's the safest way, off their road means off their maps."

SCENE 07 / BEAR'S PAW

Dense forest. No road. The lantern would be visible from too far here - it stays shut. Large paw prints in the soil ahead catch what little moonlight comes through. The sound of moving water is faint at first, growing as they follow the trail.

[Forest. Lantern closed. Paw prints just visible in the low light.]

AL-07-001 "Good news - we are off their road."

AL-07-002 "Bad news - we are off every road."

AL-07-003 "But look at the ground."

AL-07-004 "Bear prints. The Bear's Paw pattern said: follow the animal trail. Bears know where water is, where food grows, where shelter is in the cold. Before any road was ever cut through this forest, they had already mapped it."

AL-07-005 "We follow what they left. The land knows more than we do."

AL-07-006 "Reach out and trace the trail. Don't rush"

[The world responds to the trace - the path highlights just enough. Trail moves forward.]

AL-07-007 "Keep with it."

[A fork. Two directions.]

AL-07-008 "Fork here. Which way do the prints go?"

[Correct path continues. Wrong path - prints absent. If wrong:]

AL-07-009 "Other way. Look again." *[only if wrong fork chosen]*

[Correct path chosen:]

AL-07-010 "Good. Keep moving."

[Low branches.]

AL-07-011 "Down."

[The canopy drops. Then lifts.]

AL-07-012 "Up."

[A change in the sound ahead. Water - closer now, definite.]

AL-07-013 "Hold still. Listen to that."

[The water sound becomes clear. A stream through the trees.]

AL-07-014 "Water. Right there. Just like the bear prints showed us."

[They reach it. A stream - the same water that has been running through this whole journey. They drink.]

AL-07-015 "There is a town ahead. And in that town we cannot look like what we are."

SCENE 08 / BOW TIE / HOURGLASS

Edge of a town. Grey pre-dawn light. Patrol figures visible in the distance on the main road. Auntie Liza stows the lantern completely - out of sight. She produces a bundle and moves quickly.

[The lantern gone. Dawn, flat grey light. Patrol at a distance. Auntie Liza already opening the bundle.]

AL-08-001 "Hamilton. A working town; wagons, merchants, people moving. We can move through it if we look like we belong."

AL-08-002 "The Bow Tie pattern meant: change what you look like. Right now."

AL-08-003 "Hundreds of people passed through checkpoints like this one by looking like someone else for a stretch of road. That is called 'using what you have'."

AL-08-004 "The patrol does not see who is walking toward them. They see what they are shown. We are going to be very careful about what that is."

AL-08-005 "Hat first."

[The world responds - the scene itself shifts. No avatar. The environment reads differently.]

AL-08-006 "Now the coat. Arms across."

[Another shift. Transformation visible in how the world holds the space.]

AL-08-007 "You're starting to look the part."

AL-08-008 "Stand straight. Shoulders back. This is the posture of someone who belongs exactly where they are going."

AL-08-009 "Chin up. Not at the ground. You know where you are going."

AL-08-010 "Ready?"

[A beat.]

AL-08-011 "Then walk like you mean it."

[They step forward. The patrol does not turn.]

AL-08-012 "The conductor arranged a wagon on the other side of town. We just have to get to it."

SCENE 09 / WAGON WHEEL

Far edge of town. A wagon waiting on a quiet stretch of road - just where the conductor promised. Still pre-dawn. The lantern remains stowed. A driver, ready.

[The wagon. The driver. Quiet road. Morning just beginning to push at the sky.]

AL-09-001 "There it is. Right where she said."

AL-09-002 "The Wagon Wheel meant: prepare to travel by wagon. Some of these were built with compartments underneath, for exactly this purpose. Others were just a wagon on a road where wagons belonged."

AL-09-003 "Both ways have worked. Both have kept people alive. No right answer - only the one that keeps you moving."

AL-09-004 "Check the road."

[The road scanned - open, clear.]

AL-09-005 "Clear. Now choose."

--- PATH A: HIDE INSIDE ---

[The compartment visible - dark within.]

AL-09-006 "Under the boards. Still as you have ever been." *[Path A]*

[The wagon begins to move. Road sound. Quiet.]

AL-09-007 "The wagon is moving. Any sound from under there is a sound you cannot take back."
[Path A]

AL-09-008 "That kind of stillness is its own kind of strength." *[Path A - after hold]*

--- PATH B: WALK ALONGSIDE ---

[Auntie Liza moves with the wagon.]

AL-09-009 "Alongside. Steady pace. Someone who belongs on this road." *[Path B]*

AL-09-010 "Not fast, not slow. That is the pace of someone who knows exactly where they are going." *[Path B]*

--- BOTH PATHS ---

[The wheel turns. Auntie Liza reaches out and touches it.]

AL-09-011 "Every turn is a mile closer. We are getting there."

AL-09-012 "Stay sharp. Something has changed - I can feel it."

SCENE 10 / TUMBLING BLOCKS

The road. Things have been going well. Auntie Liza stops without warning. The lantern is nowhere - it was stowed in the wagon. Everything is about to accelerate.

[Stillness. Then - two sharp knocks, somewhere behind. Her whole bearing changes.]

AL-10-001 "Stop."

AL-10-002 "Listen."

[The two knocks sound - sharp, deliberate. She turns.]

AL-10-003 "That is the signal. Someone is on that road who should not be."

[Fast now. Everything accelerates.]

AL-10-004 "Pack everything. Now."

AL-10-005 "Faster!"

AL-10-006 "Clear the surface. Nothing left."

AL-10-007 "Leave nothing. Nobody was ever here."

AL-10-008 "Up."

AL-10-009 "Go."

[The world lurches forward. Speed. Dark. Movement.]

AL-10-010 "Run!"

[Running. And beneath it - rising through everything - the sound of water. Growing louder.]

AL-10-011 "I can hear it. Do you hear it?"

AL-10-012 "That is the Conestogo. We are almost there. Come on."

SCENE 11 / THE CONESTOGO - RIVER CROSSING TO QUEEN'S BUSH

The river. Wide, silver, moving under a clear sky. Water everywhere - it has been threading through the whole journey and now it surrounds them. Auntie Liza stops at the bank. She reaches into the pack and takes out the lantern. Holds it a moment, unlit. Then lights it.

[The river. Night sky. She holds the lantern unlit. A long beat. Then she lights it. It is the first time it has been fully open. She looks at the water.]

AL-11-001 "The Conestogo River."

AL-11-002 "Wellington County, Ontario."

AL-11-003 "Every time I have stood here, I have thought: this is it. This is what we were walking toward."

AL-11-004 "On the other side of this river is the Queen's Bush."

AL-11-005 "A stretch of land nobody else wanted. And because nobody else wanted it, people came and built something extraordinary."

AL-11-006 "Starting around 1820, more than fifteen hundred free and formerly enslaved Black people arrived here. They cleared this wilderness. They built farms. Churches. Schools. They named their children here and buried their elders here."

AL-11-007 "That is what is waiting across this water."

AL-11-008 "Look back before we cross. One last time."

[The world turns - the road behind briefly lit by the lantern.]

AL-11-009 "Everyone who walked that road before you. Everyone who will walk it after. You carry them when you cross."

AL-11-010 "Turn around. Let's go."

[A boat at the bank - the lantern set at the bow, fully open.]

AL-11-011 "There is a boat. Unwind it slowly."

[The boat is released onto the water.]

AL-11-012 "Launch it."

[The crossing begins.]

AL-11-013 "Row. Slow and steady."

AL-11-014 "Keep going. You are almost there."

[Midstream. The lantern on the bow. Stars reflected in the water below.]

AL-11-015 "Hold still. Feel the current."

AL-11-016 "Breathe. You are still here."

[The far shore coming. Dawn breaking.]

AL-11-017 "Touch it. Touch the ground."

[The boat reaches the far shore. The lantern's light merges with the growing dawn.]

AL-11-018 "You are here."

[The world opens. Forest, sky, the Queen's Bush in every direction. Warm full light.]

AL-11-019 "Spread your arms. All of it."

AL-11-020 "Queen's Bush. Wellington County. Canada. Yours."

[The quilt from Scene 1 reappears - seen from the other side. Every pattern visible. The lantern glows beside it.]

FINAL ADDRESS

AL-11-021 "The people who came here did not stop building when they arrived."

AL-11-022 "When the land was surveyed in the 1840s and many families could not afford to buy the plots they had been farming, they moved south to Guelph."

AL-11-023 "In 1880 they built the British Methodist Episcopal Church on Essex Street - so their children and their children's children would have a place to gather, to remember and to go on."

AL-11-024 "That church is still standing. The Guelph Black Heritage Society keeps it now. Everything it holds."

AL-11-025 "Every quilt pattern you learned - someone stitched it in secret. Every step you took on this road - someone walked it for real, in the dark, in the cold, with no guarantee of anything on the other side."

AL-11-026 "They did not stop walking."

AL-11-027 "Neither will you."

AL-11-028 "This history still stands. And you are part of it now."

[Auntie Liza lowers the lantern. Slow fade.]